NON-WSQ

CUSTOMER SERVICE

COURSE SLIDES · NON-WSQ

Customer Service Masterclass

Course Code: C529 · 1-Day Hands-On Training

Conducted by Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd · UEN 201200696W

Version v1.0 · 28 September 2026

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd. All rights reserved. · www.tertiarycourses.com.sg

COURSE ADMINISTRATION

Welcome & Housekeeping

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

About the Trainer



Your Trainer

General Trainer template —
to be completed by the trainer

NAME

TITLE / DESIGNATION

QUALIFICATIONS

AREAS OF EXPERTISE

TRAINING & INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

CONTACT

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

YOUR TRAINER

About the Trainer



Dr. Alfred Ang

Principal Trainer
Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

ROLE
Principal Trainer, Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

BACKGROUND
PhD — 20+ years of industry and training experience across service quality, business operations and technology.

DELIVERS
Courses on customer service, service branding, business improvement and digital skills.

FOUNDER
Founder and lead instructor at Tertiary Infotech / Tertiary Courses.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

ICE-BREAKER

Let's Know Each Other

1. **Your name and organisation**
   And the role you play day to day.

2. **Who your customers are**
   External, internal, or both — most people have both.

3. **A recent interaction that went badly**
   What happened, and what you think caused it.

4. **One that went well**
   What made the difference on that occasion?

5. **Your channels**
   Counter, phone, email, chat — where do you spend most of your time?

6. **What you want from today**
   One thing you want to do differently tomorrow.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

HOUSEKEEPING

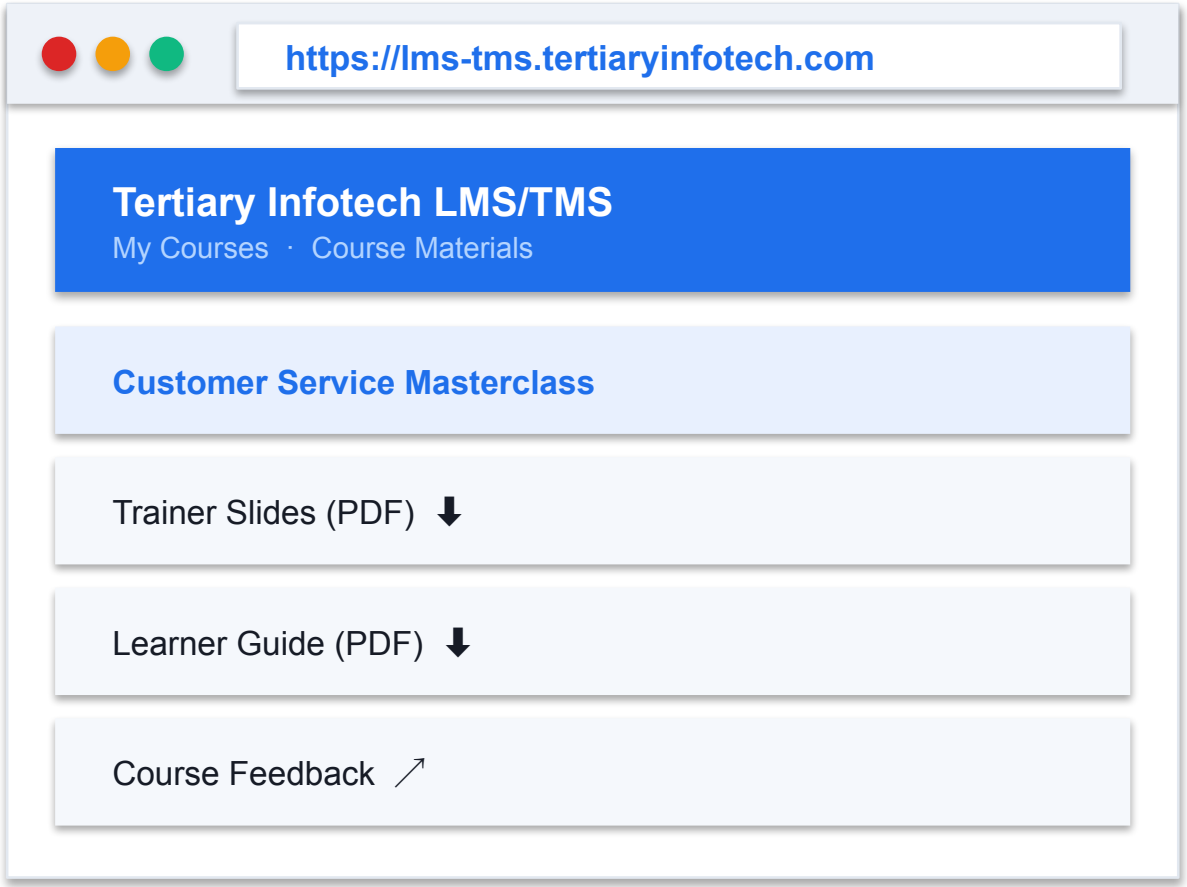
Ground Rules

1. Set your mobile phone to silent mode.
2. Participate actively — no question is too small.
3. Mutual respect: agree to disagree.
4. One conversation at a time.
5. Be punctual; return from breaks on time.
6. Full attendance — stay for the whole day to get the most from the activities.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

COURSE PORTAL · LMS/TMS

Download Course Material



1 Sign in
lms-tms.tertiaryinfotech.com — log in with your registered email (OTP or password).

2 Open your course
Select 'Customer Service Masterclass' under My Courses.

3 Download materials
Slides and the Learner Guide — your references during and after the course.

4 Share feedback
Complete the short course feedback form before you leave.

All course material is downloaded from the LMS/TMS portal — keep it handy after the course.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

SCHEDULE

Lesson Plan — 1 Day, 9:30am–5:30pm

Morning — LU1: needs & feedback

- **Morning**
  - Welcome, introductions, course outline
  - Topic 1: Understanding Customers & Service + Activity 1
  - Topic 2: Establishing Your Attitude + Activity 2
  - Topic 3: Identifying Customer Needs + Activity 3
  - Topic 4: In-Person Service + Activity 4
  - Topic 5: Phone Service
  - Lunch break 1:40–2:10pm

Afternoon — LU1 channels + LU2: improvement

- **Afternoon**
  - Activity 5: The Angry Delivery Call
  - Topic 6: Email & Chat Service + Activity 6
  - Topic 7: Return Business from Feedback + Activity 7
  - Topic 8: Recovering Difficult Customers + Activity 8
  - Topic 9: When to Escalate + Activity 9
  - Course summary, feedback and close

7.5 instructional hours · 9:30am–5:30pm · one 30-minute lunch break.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE JOURNEY

Course Outline — Two Learning Units, Nine Topics

Morning

- **LU1 — Customer's Needs and Feedback (LO1)**
  - T1 Understanding Customers & Customer Service
  - T2 Establishing Your Service Attitude
  - T3 Identifying and Addressing Customer Needs
  - T4 In-Person Customer Service
  - T5 Customer Service Over the Phone
  - T6 Customer Service via Email and Chat

Afternoon

- **LU2 — Improving Needs Based on Feedback (LO2)**
  - T7 Generating Return Business from Feedback
  - T8 Recovering Difficult Customers
  - T9 Understanding When to Escalate
- **9 real-world case-study activities**
  - Every topic is practised on a realistic Singapore scenario
  - Role plays mirror real customer interactions

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

WHY THIS COURSE MATTERS

Service is not a department.

It is every interaction a customer has with your business — before, during and after the sale.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

1

LEARNING UNIT 1

Customer's Needs and Feedback

LO1 · Collect and analyse customer feedback to assess needs and expectations

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

01

TOPIC 01

Understanding Customers & Customer Service

Who customers are · what service is · who provides it · the service-profit chain

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Topic 1 — Key Concepts

1

Service is every interaction

Customer service is the whole of the support a customer receives before, during and after a purchase — not just the complaint desk.

2

External and internal customers

External customers buy from you; internal customers are colleagues who depend on your output. Both are served.

3

Service quality is a chain

Internal support enables frontline delivery, which shapes customer experience, which drives loyalty and revenue.

4

Service is a growth centre

Help Scout: great service is a growth centre, not a cost centre — retention, referral and lifetime value all flow from it.

5

The cost of getting it wrong

86% of customers stop buying after poor experiences; US firms lose over US$62 billion a year to bad service (Help Scout).

6

Four principles of good service

Help Scout: service must be personalised, competent, convenient and proactive — all four, or the experience breaks.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE FULL SERVICE LIFECYCLE

What Customer Service Actually Covers

1 BEFORE

Pre-sales questions, product advice, quotations, expectation setting. Service starts before any money changes hands.

2 DURING

The transaction itself — ordering, payment, delivery, installation, onboarding.

3 AFTER

Support, returns, complaints, follow-up, renewal. Most loyalty is won or lost here.

4 BETWEEN

Proactive contact when nothing is wrong: updates, check-ins, warnings about issues before they bite.

Most organisations resource the middle column well and the last two poorly — which is precisely where retention is decided.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

WHO YOU SERVE

External and Internal Customers

EXTERNAL CUSTOMERS

- Buy your product or service and generate revenue.
- Judge you on the outcome AND on how they were treated.
- Can leave — and mostly leave silently, without complaining.
- Their experience is shaped by people they never meet.

INTERNAL CUSTOMERS

- Colleagues and departments who depend on your output.
- Cannot leave — so dissatisfaction shows up as friction, not churn.
- Enable (or block) the frontline's ability to serve.
- Treated as customers, they make external service possible.

The rule that runs through this whole course: excellent external service always begins with strong internal service.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE SERVICE CHAIN

How Service Quality Actually Flows



THE RULE
Excellent external service always begins with strong internal service. A break in any link becomes visible at the frontline — but it is rarely caused there.

Support enables delivery
IT, HR and operations decide what the frontline is even able to offer.

Delivery shapes perception
The customer only ever sees the last link — so that is where blame lands.

Perception drives loyalty
Loyalty and referral are downstream of experience, not of product quality alone.

Break one link, break the chain
A failure anywhere upstream surfaces as a frontline service failure.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

HELP SCOUT'S FOUR PRINCIPLES

The Four Principles of Good Service

1 PERSONALISED

A human interaction that shows the organisation actually cares about this specific customer.

2 COMPETENT

Strong product knowledge PLUS the authority to act on it. Knowledge without authority frustrates everyone.

3 CONVENIENT

Available on the channel the customer prefers, not the one cheapest for you.

4 PROACTIVE

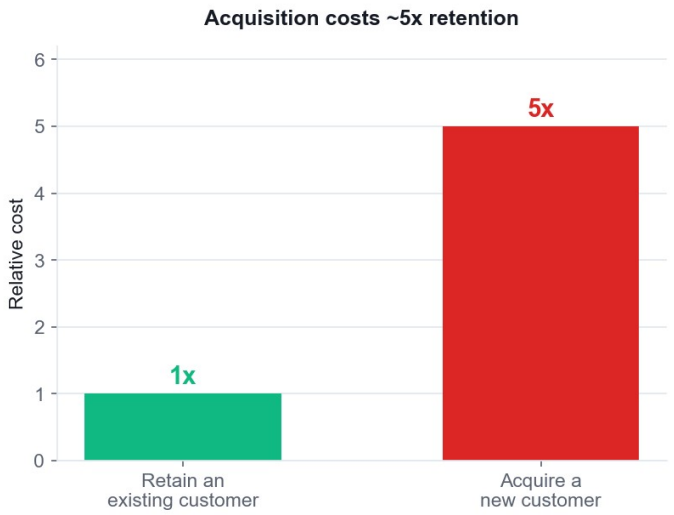
You reach out about delays and issues before the customer has to ask.

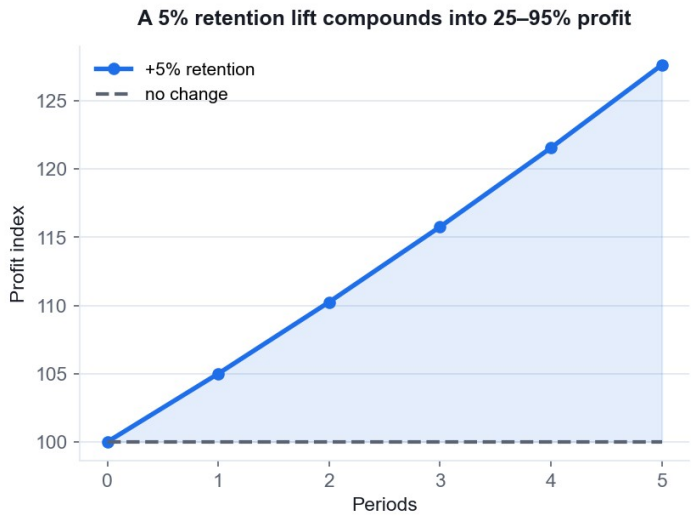
All four must hold. Personalised but incompetent is charming and useless; competent but inconvenient still loses the customer.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

WHY THE BUSINESS SHOULD CARE

The Business Case for Service





Acquisition costs ~5x

Winning a replacement customer costs far more than keeping the one you have.

Retention compounds

A 5% retention improvement can move profit by 25–95% over time.

Poor service drives churn

86% of customers stop buying after poor experiences.

Service is a growth centre

Not a cost centre — the framing decides whether it gets resourced.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

SERVICE PROVIDERS

Who Delivers Customer Service

1

Frontline staff

The first — often only — human contact. They carry the entire perception.

2

Support and back office

Never seen by the customer, but they determine what the frontline can promise.

3

Managers and leaders

Set the standards, the metrics and the amount of authority the frontline has.

4

Self-service systems

FAQ, chatbots, portals — service delivered without a person, and judged just as harshly.

5

Every other department

Product, finance, logistics — each creates or removes friction the customer feels.

6

The customer themselves

Reviews, referrals and word of mouth extend your service reputation beyond your control.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

TOPIC 01 · CASE STUDY

ACTIVITY 1 · 25 MIN

Activity 1 — Mapping the Service Chain at a Singapore Bank Branch

THE SCENARIO

OCBC-style retail branch, Tampines. Mdm Rohani, 68, comes in to reactivate a dormant savings account so her CPF payout can be credited. The queue ticket says 12 minutes; she waits 47. At the counter, the teller, Wei Ming, finds the reactivation needs a signature-verification form that Operations must approve. Operations is understaffed and quotes 3 working days. Wei Ming has no authority to expedite and no way to see the Operations queue. Mdm Rohani has already made two trips. She says loudly that she will move her account to another bank, and other customers in the queue are listening.

Behind the counter: the branch manager has a service-level dashboard showing counter wait times but not back-office turnaround. Operations measures forms processed per day, not customer trips avoided. The digital team launched an app-based reactivation two months ago that nobody told the branch about.

FORMAT Case Study + Peer Sharing

ROLES Groups of 4–5. Each group maps the chain; one member presents.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 1 · Activities folder: activities/activity-01/

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

TOPIC 01 · WORK IN YOUR GROUP

Activity 1 — Discussion Questions

1. Who are the EXTERNAL customers in this case, and who are the INTERNAL customers? List every one.
2. Draw the service chain from Mdm Rohani's need to the outcome she actually got. Where exactly did it break?
3. Wei Ming was polite and followed procedure, and the customer still left angry. Whose service failure is this?
4. Operations measures 'forms processed per day'. What behaviour does that metric produce, and what does it miss?
5. The app-based reactivation existed but the branch did not know. What internal service failure does that reveal?
6. Name one change per link in the chain that would have prevented this outcome.

20 minutes · Groups of 4–5. Each group maps the chain; one member presents.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 1 — Debrief

The frontline is where the failure BECOMES VISIBLE, not where it is caused. Wei Ming did nothing wrong — he was set up to fail by the links behind him.

Internal customers here: Wei Ming is Operations' customer; the branch is the digital team's customer; Operations is the branch manager's customer. Every one of those relationships failed.

'Forms processed per day' optimises throughput, not resolution. It is blind to Mdm Rohani's THREE trips — the metric would look healthy while the customer churns.

The undisclosed app feature is a pure internal-communication failure. A capability the frontline does not know about does not exist.

Expected fixes: give the teller visibility of the Operations queue; give SOMEONE authority to expedite; measure customer trips not forms; brief the branch on every new digital capability.

Link back to Topic 1: excellent external service always begins with strong internal service. This case is the proof.

TEST IT Your map names at least 3 internal customers, marks at least 3 broken links, and each fix is a specific action with an owner.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

02

TOPIC 02

Establishing Your Service Attitude

Appearance · the power of a smile · staying energised · staying positive · positive language

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Topic 2 — Key Concepts

1

Attitude is visible instantly

First impressions form in 4–7 seconds; roughly 55% of that impression comes from appearance and body language.

2

Emotions are contagious

Your mood transfers to the customer. A genuine smile measurably raises trust and how welcome a guest feels.

3

Positive language reframes limits

'That's back-ordered' becomes 'That's available next month — I can reserve it now.' Same fact, different outcome.

4

Energy must be managed

Service quality decays with fatigue. Structured micro-breaks and shift resets protect the last customer of the day.

5

Resilience is a trained skill

Zendesk lists resilience as core: absorbing criticism without letting it degrade the next interaction.

6

Professionalism is the baseline

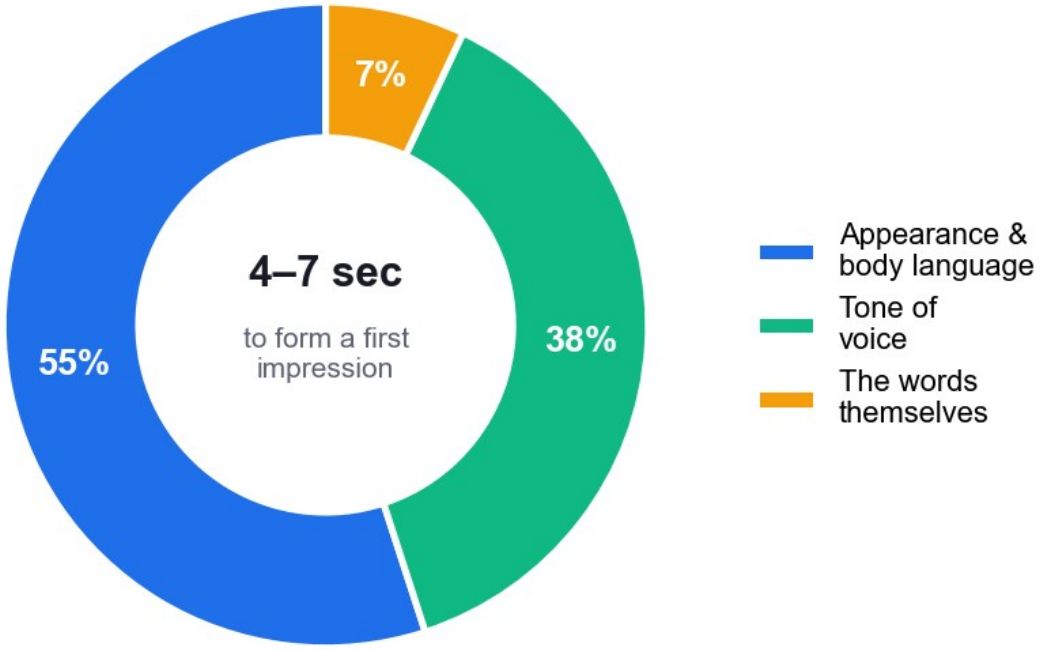
Respectful tone, accuracy and appropriate boundaries held consistently — regardless of how the customer behaves.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE ATTITUDE MOMENT

First Impressions Form Before You Speak

Your attitude is visible before you speak



4–7 seconds
The window in which the customer decides how this is going to go.

55% is what they see
Grooming, posture, expression — visible before a word is exchanged.

38% is how you sound
Tone, pace and warmth carry more than the words themselves.

7% is what you say
Correct words delivered badly still read as bad service.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

ESTABLISHING YOUR ATTITUDE

The Four Pillars of Service Attitude

1 APPEARANCE

Professional grooming signals competence and respect. It is the baseline expectation in Singapore hospitality and retail.

2 THE SMILE

A genuine smile measurably raises trust. A forced one is detected instantly and costs more than none.

3 ENERGY

Service quality decays with fatigue. Managed breaks protect the last customer of the day.

4 POSITIVITY

Reframe the limit into what IS possible. Do not take the complaint personally.

Attitude is not a personality trait you either have or lack — every one of these four pillars is a trainable, repeatable behaviour.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE HIGHEST-LEVERAGE HABIT IN THIS COURSE

Positive Language — Same Facts, Opposite Outcome

NEGATIVE FRAMING

- "That product is back-ordered and unavailable."
- "I don't know."
- "You have to log out first."
- "That's not our policy."
- "You'll have to pay for that yourself."
- "There's nothing I can do."

POSITIVE FRAMING

- "That's available next month — I can reserve it now."
- "Let me find out for you."
- "Logging out should fix that quickly!"
- "Here's what I can do for you."
- "I can book that for you at the member rate."
- "Let me get someone who can authorise that."

Positive language does not mean saying yes. It means directing the customer to what IS available — with the same underlying answer.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

STAYING ENERGISED AND POSITIVE

Managing Yourself Across a Shift

1

Emotional contagion

Your mood transfers to the customer within seconds — and theirs to you.

2

Reset between customers

One breath and a deliberate posture reset stops case 11 inheriting case 10's frustration.

3

Micro-breaks work

Short structured breaks measurably protect service quality later in the shift.

4

Depersonalise the complaint

They are angry at the situation, at the company, at their day — not at you.

5

Resilience is trainable

Absorb criticism, extract the useful part, discard the rest, start clean.

6

Know your own tells

Flat tone, short answers, no eye contact — learn to catch your own fatigue signals.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

ACTIVITY 2 · 15 MIN

Activity 2 — Attitude and Positive Language at a Changi Airport Service Counter

THE SCENARIO

Changi Airport Terminal 3, airline transfer desk, 11:40pm. Mr Krishnan and his two children (aged 4 and 7) have missed their connecting flight to Chennai because the inbound flight was delayed by weather. The next available flight is 14 hours away. Company policy for weather delays: no hotel accommodation, no meal vouchers, rebooking only. The children are crying. Mr Krishnan has been queueing for 35 minutes and is the eleventh passenger you have seen with the same problem tonight. You are 90 minutes past the end of your shift.

What you CAN do: rebook him on the 1:50pm flight; give him lounge access at your discretion; provide a transit hotel booking form at his own cost; escalate to the duty manager for a goodwill exception.

FORMAT Role Play + Peer Sharing

ROLES Pairs. Role A = Service Officer, Role B = Mr Krishnan. Swap after the first round. Observers score.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 2 · Activities folder: activities/activity-02/

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 2 — Discussion Questions

1. Rewrite each phrase in positive language: 'We don't cover weather delays.' / 'There's nothing I can do.' / 'You'll have to pay for that yourself.' / 'That's not our policy.' / 'I don't know.'
2. You are 90 minutes past your shift end and this is the eleventh identical case. How does that show up in your body language and voice, even when your words are correct?
3. The answer to 'will you pay for my hotel?' is genuinely no. How do you say no and still leave the customer feeling served?
4. What can you offer that costs the company little but changes how Mr Krishnan experiences this? Name three things.
5. At what point, if any, would you escalate to the duty manager — and what would you say to Mr Krishnan as you do it?
6. The two crying children are not your customer, but they change the interaction. How?

15 minutes · Pairs. Role A = Service Officer, Role B = Mr Krishnan. Swap after the first round. Observers score.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 2 — Debrief

Positive language does not mean saying yes. It means directing the customer to what IS available: 'I can get you on the 1:50pm and into the lounge now' beats 'we don't cover weather delays' with the same underlying answer.

'I don't know' becomes 'let me find out' — the second is the same information plus ownership.

Fatigue leaks through the non-verbal channel first. Words stay professional long after tone and posture have given up. Observers should watch for flat tone, no eye contact, and a sigh before speaking.

The three low-cost offers most groups find: lounge access (comfort for the kids), a proactive rebooking done before he asks, and a printed confirmation so he does not have to re-explain at the next desk.

Acknowledge the children explicitly — the customer's stress is mostly about them. Serving the parent means noticing the kids.

Escalation here is not defeat: naming the duty manager and saying 'I want to ask if we can make an exception for you' shows the customer you are on their side of the counter.

TEST IT You delivered a genuine 'no' inside 2 minutes, offered at least two alternatives unprompted, and your partner reports feeling served rather than dismissed.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

03

TOPIC 03

Identifying and Addressing Customer Needs

Active listening · questioning · the four levels of need · going the extra mile

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

TOPIC 03 · LU1 · 60 min

Topic 3 — Key Concepts

1

Needs are functional and emotional

The product must work (functional) and the customer must feel valued (emotional). Missing either loses the customer.

2

Active listening is the core skill

Attend fully, paraphrase back, read the cues, then confirm. Only 17% of customers believe businesses actually listen (Tidio).

3

Ask before you prescribe

Open questions surface the real need; closed questions confirm it. Diagnosing before solving prevents the wrong fix.

4

Attentiveness reads the unsaid

Repeated 'I couldn't find it' across customers is a UX defect report, not a series of individual questions.

5

Four levels of addressing needs

Understand the problem → meet the basic need → think outside the box → go the extra mile.

6

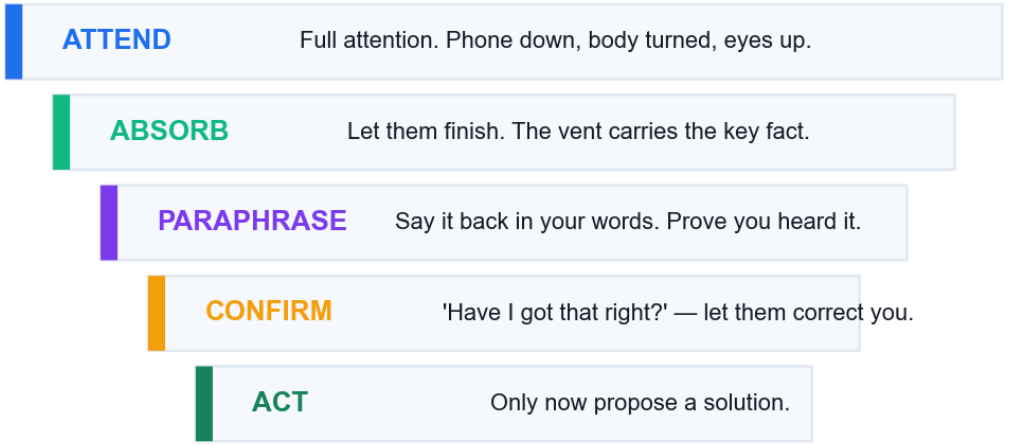
Personalisation drives loyalty

Use history and context; 35% would rather deal with an AI than repeat themselves to a human (Salesforce).

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE CORE SERVICE SKILL

Active Listening — Making Listening Visible



Only 17% of customers believe businesses actually listen to them. Paraphrasing is what makes listening visible.

Attend
Full attention. Phone down, body turned, eyes up. Half-attention is detected instantly.

Absorb
Let them finish. The vent almost always contains the key fact.

Paraphrase
Say it back in your own words — this is what makes listening visible.

Confirm, then act
'Have I got that right?' Only after a yes do you propose a solution.

Only 17% of customers believe businesses actually listen to them — paraphrasing is the cheapest way to be in the other 83%.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

DIAGNOSE BEFORE YOU PRESCRIBE

Questioning — Open to Explore, Closed to Confirm

CLOSED QUESTIONS (confirm)

- "Is the account under your name?"
- "Did you receive the confirmation email?"
- "Would Tuesday work for delivery?"
- Use to: pin down facts, confirm, close a decision.
- Risk: asking these first makes it an interrogation.

OPEN QUESTIONS (explore)

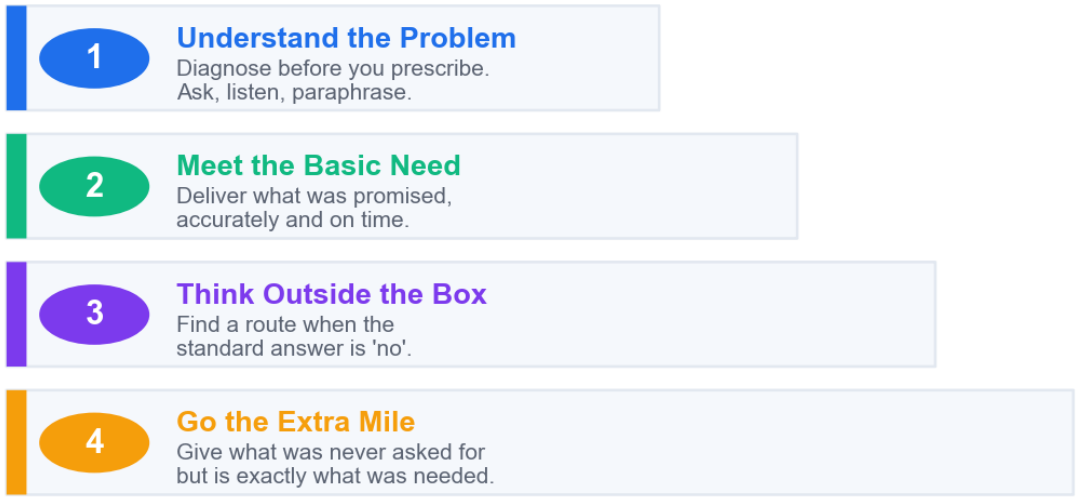
- "Walk me through what happened."
- "What were you expecting to see?"
- "How is this affecting your work?"
- Use to: surface the real need and the emotion behind it.
- Rule: if it can be answered yes/no, rewrite it.

Open first to understand, closed second to confirm. Reversing the order is the most common needs-identification failure.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

A LADDER, NOT A MENU

The Four Levels of Addressing Customer Needs



Each level is only available once the level below it is solid.

1 · Understand

Diagnose the actual problem before offering any solution.

2 · Meet the basic need

Deliver what was promised, accurately and on time. Non-negotiable.

3 · Outside the box

Find a route when the standard answer is 'no'.

4 · The extra mile

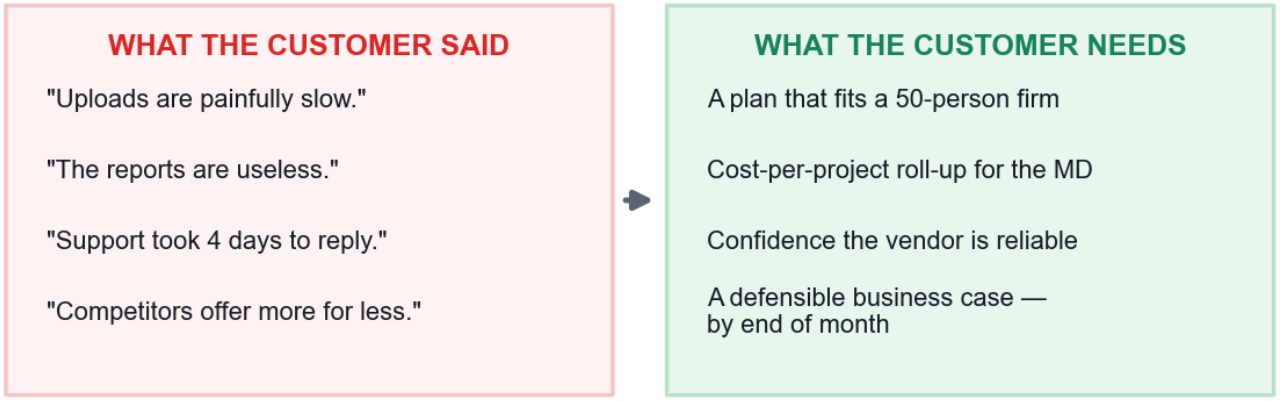
Give what was never asked for but was exactly what was needed.

Level 4 delivered while level 2 is failing reads as a distraction — you cannot skip the rungs.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE INFERENCE THAT MATTERS

What They Said vs What They Need



The complaints are symptoms. The last line of the email is the actual brief. Solve only the left column and you still lose the account.

Complaints are symptoms

The stated problem is where they started, not where the need lives.

Functional vs emotional

The product must work AND the customer must feel valued.

Listen for the deadline

The real brief is often the last sentence, not the first.

Attentiveness reads patterns

The same complaint from many customers is a defect report.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

TOPIC 03 · CASE STUDY

ACTIVITY 3 · 25 MIN

Activity 3 — Diagnosing Customer Needs at a Growing SME — TechNova Account Review

THE SCENARIO

TechNova Solutions (Singapore) supplies a cloud project-management platform. Mr Daniel Lim is Operations Director at Horizon Builders Pte Ltd, a Woodlands-based construction firm and a customer for 6 years. Horizon has grown from 12 to 50 employees. Daniel emails: 'Uploads are painfully slow, the reports are useless for what we need, and it took your support team 4 days to answer my last ticket. Competitors are offering us more for less. I need to justify this renewal to my MD by end of month.'

What the account record shows: Horizon is on Team Pro (a 15-seat plan) with 50 users sharing logins. Upload slowness correlates with 200MB+ site photo batches — the plan caps concurrent uploads. The reporting Daniel wants (cost-per-project roll-up) exists in the Enterprise tier. The 4-day ticket was logged during the Chinese New Year holiday period. Daniel has never had a formal account review in 6 years.

FORMAT Case Study + Role Play

ROLES Pairs. Role A = TechNova Account Manager, Role B = Daniel Lim. Assessor-style observer optional.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 3 · Activities folder: activities/activity-03/

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

TOPIC 03 · WORK IN YOUR GROUP

Activity 3 — Discussion Questions

1. Separate what Daniel SAID from what Daniel NEEDS. Write two columns. They are not the same list.
2. Identify Daniel's FUNCTIONAL needs and his EMOTIONAL needs. Which one is driving the email's tone?
3. 'I need to justify this renewal to my MD by end of month.' What does this sentence tell you that the complaints do not?
4. Map your findings to the four levels: understand the problem / meet basic needs / think outside the box / go the extra mile. What sits at each level?
5. Horizon has 50 users on a 15-seat plan. This is a contract breach AND the cause of the slowness. How do you raise it without turning a save into a fight?
6. Six years, no account review. What does that reveal about TechNova's own service process — and what should change?

20 minutes · Pairs. Role A = TechNova Account Manager, Role B = Daniel Lim. Assessor-style observer optional.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 3 — Debrief

Said vs needed: he SAYS slow uploads, useless reports, slow support. He NEEDS a defensible business case for his MD by month end. Solve only the first three and you still lose the account.

The emotional need is dominant: Daniel is exposed in front of his MD. The functional fixes are the evidence he needs to not look foolish for having stayed 6 years.

The last sentence is the actual brief. Everything before it is symptoms. Learners who spot this are doing genuine needs identification rather than complaint triage.

Four levels — understand: the plan no longer fits a 50-person firm. Basic: fix the upload cap and the ticket SLA. Outside the box: the seat overage is leverage for a migration, not a penalty. Extra mile: build the cost-per-project report FOR his MD deck.

The 15-seat breach must be raised as a discovery, not an accusation: 'your growth has outrun the plan we sold you six years ago — that's on us for not reviewing it.'

The real service failure is TechNova's: no account review in 6 years means nobody was listening until the customer shouted. The process fix is a scheduled review cadence — this is a Topic 7 closed-loop point arriving early.

TEST IT Your needs analysis has at least one emotional need identified, all four levels populated, and your role-play partner confirms you surfaced the MD deadline as the real brief.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

04

TOPIC 04

In-Person Customer Service

Walk-ins and at-your-desk requests · body language · advantages and limits of face-to-face

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Topic 4 — Key Concepts

1

Face-to-face is highest bandwidth

Tone, posture, expression and timing all carry meaning that text channels strip away.

2

Immediate feedback loop

Misunderstandings surface and are corrected within seconds — the strongest advantage over email or chat.

3

Body language you control

Open posture, ~70% eye contact, a slight forward lean and subtle mirroring build rapport without a word.

4

Signals that cost you trust

Crossed arms, glancing at a phone, turning away or a fixed forced smile all read as disengagement.

5

Acknowledge within seconds

Greet a walk-in within about 3 seconds even when occupied; being seen matters before being served.

6

The limits of in-person

No automatic record, queueing pressure and scheduling conflicts — document afterwards or it never happened.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

CHOOSING FACE-TO-FACE

In-Person Service — Strengths and Limits

THE LIMITATIONS

- No automatic record — if you don't write it down, it didn't happen.
- Queueing pressure: everyone waiting sees how long you take.
- You can only serve one person at a time.
- Scheduling conflicts and walk-in unpredictability.
- Harder to escalate discreetly with an audience present.

THE ADVANTAGES

- Immediate feedback — misunderstandings die in seconds.
- Full non-verbal bandwidth: posture, expression, timing.
- Strongest channel for building trust and rapport.
- Easiest channel on which to de-escalate genuine anger.
- You can show, demonstrate and hand over physically.

The channel's great weakness is memory: always follow a face-to-face resolution with a written summary.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE NON-VERBAL CHANNEL

Body Language You Control

1 POSTURE

Open and uncrossed, with a slight forward lean. Signals engagement and honesty.

2 EYE CONTACT

Around 70% of the time. Constant staring intimidates; avoidance reads as dishonesty.

3 MIRRORING

Subtly match their pace and energy. Builds rapport below conscious awareness.

4 THE SMILE

Genuine and brief at greeting. It sets the emotional tone for everything after.

Signals that cost you trust: crossed arms, glancing at your phone, turning your torso away, or a fixed forced smile.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE PARK AND RETURN METHOD

Handling a Walk-In While You Are Already Busy

1. **Acknowledge within 3 seconds**
   Eye contact, a raised hand, 'I'll be right with you.' Being SEEN precedes being served.

2. **Give a realistic wait**
   'About two minutes' buys you two minutes. A vague wait buys you nothing.

3. **Protect the active customer**
   The person you are serving keeps priority — say so openly so the queue hears the rule.

4. **Note your park point**
   Record where you stopped so you resume without making anyone repeat themselves.

5. **Return and reference**
   Open with what they told you: 'you mentioned a cracked screen' proves you were listening.

6. **Close with next steps**
   Summarise what happens now, so they leave with certainty rather than hope.

Making a customer re-explain their problem is the single failure this method exists to prevent.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

TOPIC 04 · CASE STUDY

ACTIVITY 4 · 15 MIN

Activity 4 — The Walk-In Interruption — Retail Service Counter, Bugis

THE SCENARIO

A telco retail store at Bugis Junction, Saturday 2pm. You are at the service counter finishing a SIM registration for a customer who is standing beside you waiting for the confirmation SMS. The store phone rings. At the same moment, Ms Chen walks up to your counter holding a phone with a cracked screen and says 'Excuse me, I just need a quick answer' — she has been in the store for 20 minutes looking for someone. Two more customers are visibly waiting behind her.

You cannot serve three people at once. Everything you do in the next 15 seconds is visible to all of them.

FORMAT Role Play

ROLES Groups of 4. Role A = Service Officer, B = SIM customer, C = Ms Chen, D = observer/phone caller.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 4 · Activities folder: activities/activity-04/

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 4 — Discussion Questions

1. In the first 15 seconds, what do you do — and in what order? Be specific about words, eyes and hands.
2. Ms Chen says 'I just need a quick answer'. Is it ever actually quick? What is the risk of treating it as quick?
3. How do you acknowledge Ms Chen without abandoning the customer already at your counter?
4. The phone is ringing and no one else can take it. What do you do, and what does the customer in front of you see you do?
5. What body language keeps all three parties feeling attended to while you can only serve one?
6. What is the 'park and return' method, and where exactly would you use it here?

15 minutes · Groups of 4. Role A = Service Officer, B = SIM customer, C = Ms Chen, D = observer/phone caller.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 4 — Debrief

Order matters: eye contact + a raised hand + 'I'll be right with you, about two minutes' to Ms Chen takes 3 seconds and buys 2 minutes. Being SEEN precedes being served.

'Quick answer' is almost never quick — a cracked screen means warranty status, purchase date, insurance and a repair booking. Treating it as quick means starting something you cannot finish and now failing two customers.

The customer in front of you keeps priority. State that openly to the room: it reassures the person you are serving AND tells the queue there is a fair rule.

The phone: let it go to the queue or answer with 'may I take your number and call you back in five minutes?' Never leave a physical customer standing while you have a full phone conversation — the person present outranks the person calling.

Body language: keep your torso oriented to the counter customer, turn only your head to Ms Chen, and use an open palm rather than a pointed finger. Turning your whole body away is the abandonment signal.

Park and return: note where you were in the SIM registration before you turn away, so you resume without asking the first customer to repeat anything. Making a customer re-explain is the failure this method exists to prevent.

TEST IT You acknowledged the walk-in within 5 seconds, no customer was asked to repeat themselves, and the observer confirms you never fully turned away from the customer you were actively serving.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Lunch Break

1:40pm – 2:10pm

05

TOPIC 05

Customer Service Over the Phone

Telephone etiquette · voice as the whole channel · hold and transfer · call structure

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Topic 5 — Key Concepts

1

Voice carries everything

With no visual channel, tone, pace and warmth do all the work that body language does in person.

2

Phone still dominates complex issues

When an issue needs back-and-forth clarification, customers still reach for the phone over text channels.

3

Etiquette is measurable

Answer within three rings, smile while speaking, never interrupt, avoid jargon, always close with next steps.

4

Hold is a permission, not an action

Ask before holding, explain why, give a time, thank them on return — otherwise it reads as being dumped.

5

Paraphrase to prove you listened

'So the order was due Monday and hasn't arrived' converts a vent into a defined, solvable problem.

6

Scripts guide, they don't speak

Rigid scripts sound robotic. Use them as a spine and personalise the words to the caller in front of you.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE CALL STRUCTURE

The Professional Call — Six Stages



The four-part hold is where most calls are lost: ask permission · state the reason · give a duration · thank them on return.

Greet and listen

Within three rings, smile first, then let them finish without interruption.

Paraphrase and confirm

Say the whole issue back. Wait for their yes before moving on.

Hold properly

Ask, explain, give a duration, thank them on return. All four, every time.

Resolve and close

Options with a recommendation, then a time, an owner and a reference number.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Telephone Service — What Loses and Wins Calls

WHAT LOSES THE CALL

- Interrupting to defend the company mid-vent.
- Silent hold with no reason and no time given.
- Reading a rigid script — it sounds robotic instantly.
- Jargon and internal system names.
- Vague closes: 'we'll look into it and get back to you.'
- Transferring without explaining or introducing.

WHAT WINS THE CALL

- Letting the first 30–45 seconds run — the key fact is in there.
- Smiling before you speak — it changes your voice audibly.
- Using their name naturally, two or three times.
- Paraphrasing before proposing anything.
- A specific time, a named owner and a reference number.
- One proactive follow-up call, made whether or not it worked.

With no visual channel, tone and pace do all the work that posture and expression do in person.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

WHERE MOST CALLS ARE LOST

Placing a Customer on Hold — the Four Parts

1

Ask permission

'May I put you on hold for a moment?' — then actually wait for the answer.

2

State the reason

'…while I get my supervisor to authorise the re-route.' Reason converts waiting into progress.

3

Give a realistic duration

'About three minutes.' Then beat it, or come back and re-contract.

4

Thank them on return

'Thank you for waiting.' Missing this one part makes the whole hold feel like being dumped.

A hold is a permission you are granted, not an action you perform on the customer.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

ACTIVITY 5 · 15 MIN

Activity 5 — The Angry Delivery Call — Logistics Hotline

THE SCENARIO

You work the customer hotline for a Singapore last-mile logistics firm. Mr Faisal calls at 4:15pm. His package — a replacement CPAP machine part his father needs — was due Monday. It is now Thursday. Tracking has said 'out for delivery' for three days. He has called twice before; both times he was told 'it will be delivered today'. He opens the call at volume: 'I've been lied to twice. Don't tell me it's out for delivery. Where is my package?'

What you find while he is talking: the parcel was mis-sorted to the Jurong hub on Monday, scanned back out Wednesday, and is genuinely on a van today — but the van's route ends at 9pm and he is stop 61 of 68. You can request a priority re-route (needs hub supervisor approval, ~10 minutes) or offer next-morning guaranteed delivery before 10am.

FORMAT Role Play

ROLES Pairs, seated back to back so there is no visual channel. A = Hotline Officer, B = Mr Faisal.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 5 · Activities folder: activities/activity-05/

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

TOPIC 05 · WORK IN YOUR GROUP

Activity 5 — Discussion Questions

1. Mr Faisal opens by shouting. What are your first words, and how long do you let him talk before you speak?
2. He says 'I've been lied to twice.' Is that true? How do you respond to it without blaming a colleague or defending the company?
3. Write the exact sentence you would use to paraphrase his issue back to him.
4. You need 10 minutes to get supervisor approval. How do you place him on hold correctly — what four things must you say?
5. You have two options (priority re-route vs guaranteed next morning). Do you choose for him or offer both? Why?
6. Why does the CPAP detail change how you handle this call, and what would you have missed if you had interrupted him?

15 minutes · Pairs, seated back to back so there is no visual channel. A = Hotline Officer, B = Mr Faisal.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 5 — Debrief

Let him finish. The first 30–45 seconds are venting and contain the CPAP detail — the single most important fact in the call. An officer who interrupts to defend the tracking system never learns why this parcel matters.

'I've been lied to twice' — do not defend and do not blame. 'You were given a delivery promise twice and it did not happen. That's on us.' Acknowledging the customer's EXPERIENCE is not admitting to a lie.

Good paraphrase: 'So your father's CPAP part was promised Monday, you've called twice, been told it's out for delivery each time, and four days on you still have nothing.' Naming the father is what proves you listened.

Correct hold has four parts: ask permission, state the reason, give a realistic duration, thank them on return. Missing any one of these makes the hold feel like being dumped.

Offer both options with a recommendation. The CPAP context makes guaranteed 10am delivery likely better than stop 61 at 9pm — but it is his father and his call. Choosing FOR the customer removes the one piece of control he still has.

This call is a Topic 7 case in disguise: the mis-sort is the fault, but the SERVICE failure is two false promises. Note it for the feedback loop — the fix is not promising a date the system cannot see.

TEST IT You did not interrupt during the opening vent, your paraphrase included the father/CPAP detail, your hold had all four elements, and your close named a specific time and owner.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

06

TOPIC 06

Customer Service via Email and Chat

Netiquette · email structure · written tone · choosing between email and live chat

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Topic 6 — Key Concepts

1

Writing is a service skill

'You have to log out first' and 'Logging out should fix that quickly!' carry identical information and opposite tone.

2

Email creates the record

The written trail is the channel's real advantage: the customer can re-read it and you can prove what was agreed.

3

Netiquette rules are not optional

No ALL CAPS, no unexplained jargon, a clear action-oriented subject line and a real signature block.

4

A five-part email structure

Personalised greeting → acknowledge the issue → give the solution → state next steps → professional sign-off.

5

Email vs live chat

Email suits complex, documented, attachment-bearing issues; chat suits short, real-time, single-question issues.

6

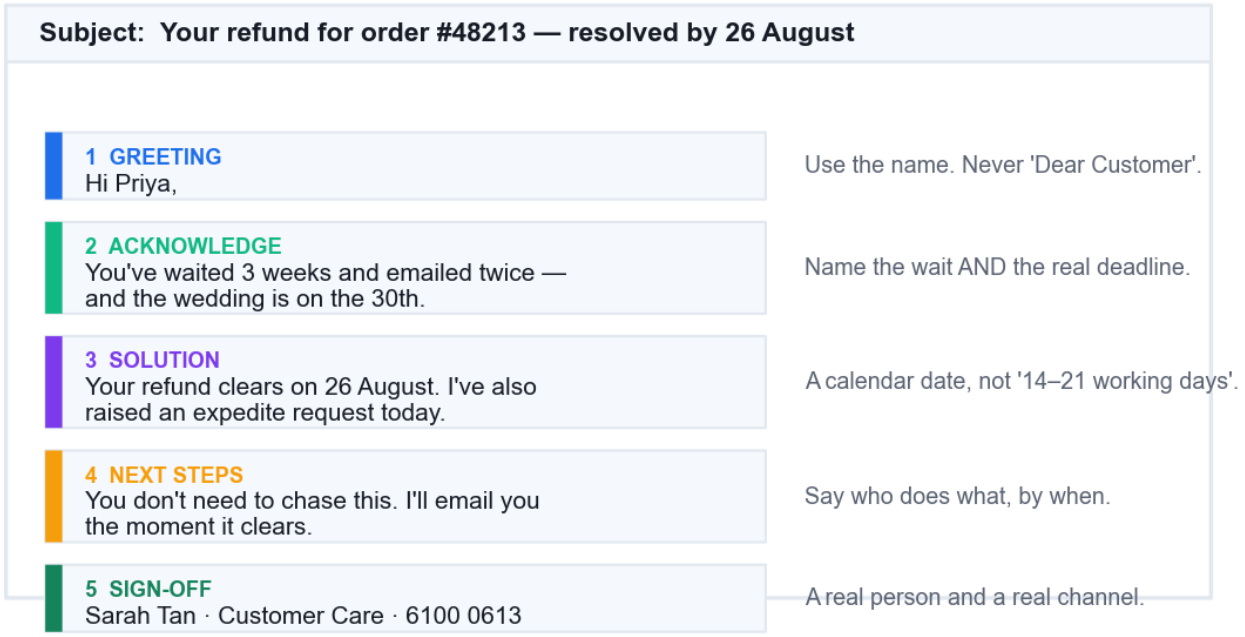
Proofread before you send

Grammar and spelling errors read as carelessness and quietly transfer to how the customer rates your competence.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE FIVE-PART STRUCTURE

The Anatomy of a Service Email



Greeting

Their name, always. 'Dear Customer' announces that nobody read the file.

Acknowledge

Name the wait, the prior contacts and the real deadline before anything else.

Solution

A calendar date, not a working-day range. Ranges read as evasion.

Next steps + sign-off

Who does what by when — signed by a real, named person.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

WRITTEN TONE IS A SERVICE SKILL

Netiquette — What Breaks a Service Email

NEVER

- ALL CAPS — it reads as shouting.
- 'Dear Customer' when you have their name on file.
- Policy citations as an answer ('per T&C 7.3').
- 'Please do not email again' — you just closed their only channel.
- Unsigned 'Support Team' with no human name.
- Dead subject lines: 'RE: RE: FW: order'.

ALWAYS

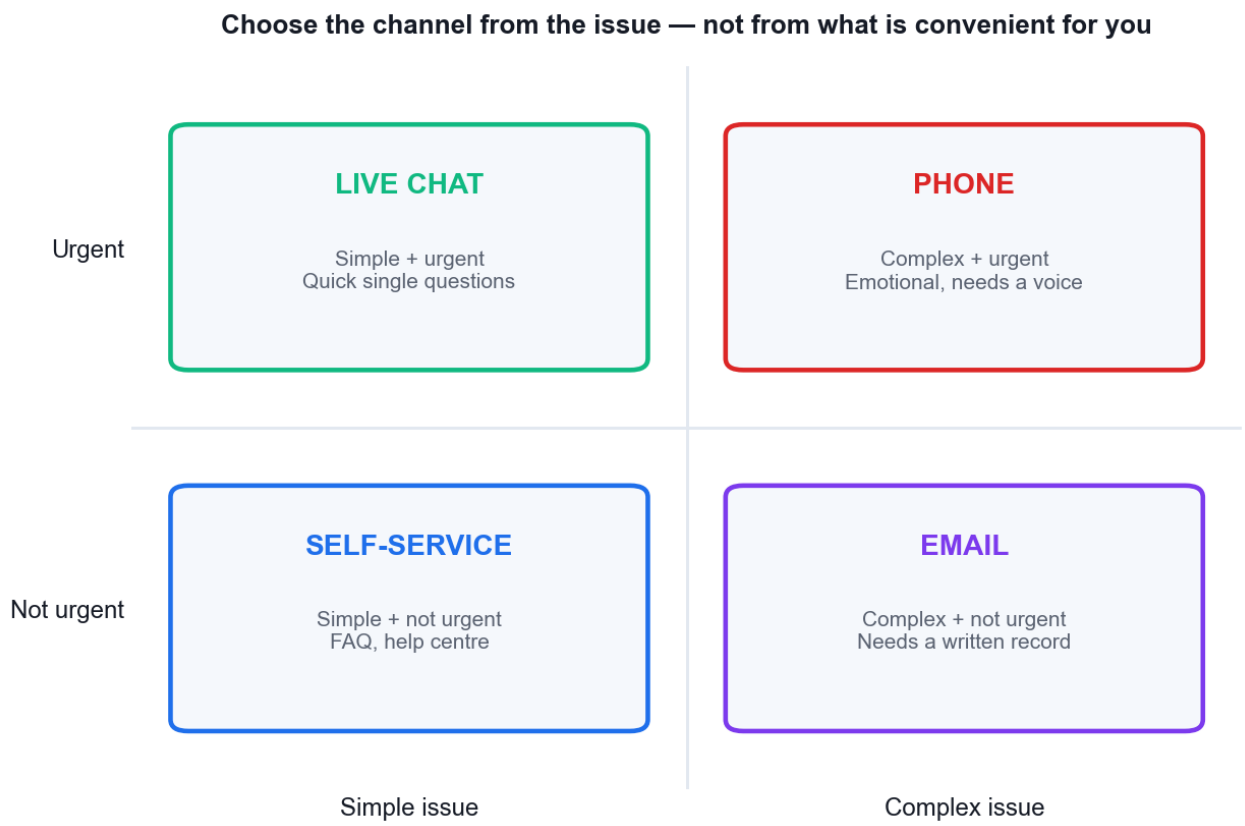
- A clear, action-oriented subject line.
- Their name, and a reference to their history with you.
- Plain language — explain the policy, don't cite it.
- A concrete date and a named owner.
- A real signature: name, role, direct contact.
- A proofread pass before you send.

An email can be 100% factually correct and still be a total service failure — accuracy is not the same as service.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

MATCH THE CHANNEL TO THE ISSUE

Choosing the Right Channel



Phone
Complex and urgent, or emotionally charged. Voice carries what text cannot.

Live chat
Simple and urgent — one quick question, answered in real time.

Email
Complex, not urgent, needs attachments and a durable written record.

Self-service
Simple and not urgent — FAQ and help centre, available at 3am.

Best practice for a time-critical emotional issue: call first, then confirm in writing — use each channel for what it does well.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

ACTIVITY 6 · 15 MIN

Activity 6 — Rewriting the Refund Email — E-Commerce Support Inbox

THE SCENARIO

A Singapore online fashion retailer. Ms Priya ordered a dress for her sister's wedding on 2 August, paid S$189, and received the wrong size. She returned it on 8 August using the prepaid label. It is now 22 August, no refund has appeared, and the wedding is on 30 August. She has emailed twice.

The agent's reply, sent as-is:

Subject: RE: RE: FW: order

FORMAT Case Study + Practical Writing

ROLES Individually, then compare in pairs.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 6 · Activities folder: activities/activity-06/

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 6 — Discussion Questions

1. List every netiquette failure in the agent's email. There are at least seven.
2. Every fact in the email is accurate. Explain how an email can be 100% correct and still be a service failure.
3. What is the customer's REAL deadline, and does the agent's reply acknowledge it at all?
4. Rewrite the email using the five-part structure: greeting → acknowledge → solution → next steps → sign-off.
5. 'Please do not email again.' What does this sentence do to the relationship, and what should replace it?
6. Should this have been email, live chat or a phone call? Justify your choice against the channel-selection rule.

15 minutes · Individually, then compare in pairs.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 6 — Debrief

Netiquette failures to find: 'RE: RE: FW: order' subject line, 'Dear Customer' not her name, ALL CAPS as shouting, policy-section jargon (T&C 7.3), no apology or acknowledgement, an instruction not to make contact, an unsigned 'Support Team' with no individual name, and no next step the customer can act on.

Correct-but-failing is the key lesson: the agent answered the question the customer TYPED and ignored the question she MEANT — 'will I have this sorted before the wedding on the 30th?'

The wedding date is the real deadline and the email never mentions it. This is the same 'said vs needed' distinction from Activity 3, in writing.

A good rewrite names Priya, acknowledges two prior emails and the wedding, states the refund date with a specific day, offers something concrete (expedite request, or a replacement in the right size shipped now), and gives a named person and direct contact.

'Please do not email again' tells the customer her only channel is closed. Replace with proactive ownership: 'You don't need to chase this — I'll email you the moment it clears, and here's my direct line.'

Channel: email is right for the RECORD (money, dates, policy), but this case needed a phone call first because it is time-critical and emotional. Best practice is call, then confirm in writing — using both channels for what each does well.

TEST IT Your rewrite has all five parts, names the customer, acknowledges the 30 August wedding, gives a calendar date rather than a working-day range, and is signed by a named person.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

2

LEARNING UNIT 2

Improving Customer's Needs Based on Feedback

LO2 · Identify and recommend areas for improvement from feedback and operational insight

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

07

TOPIC 07

Generating Return Business from Feedback

Feedback channels · closing the loop · complaint handling · retention economics

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Topic 7 — Key Concepts

1

Retention beats acquisition

Keeping a customer costs far less than winning a new one; a 5% retention lift can move profit 25–95%.

2

Feedback channels are a portfolio

Surveys, reviews, interviews, social listening, support tickets and staff reports — each has a bias, so triangulate.

3

CSAT, NPS and CES measure differently

CSAT rates a moment, NPS rates the relationship, CES rates the effort the customer had to spend.

4

Most unhappy customers say nothing

Roughly 56% leave silently. The absence of complaints is not evidence of satisfaction.

5

Closing the loop is the point

Collect → analyse → act → tell the customer what changed. Feedback with no visible action trains people to stop giving it.

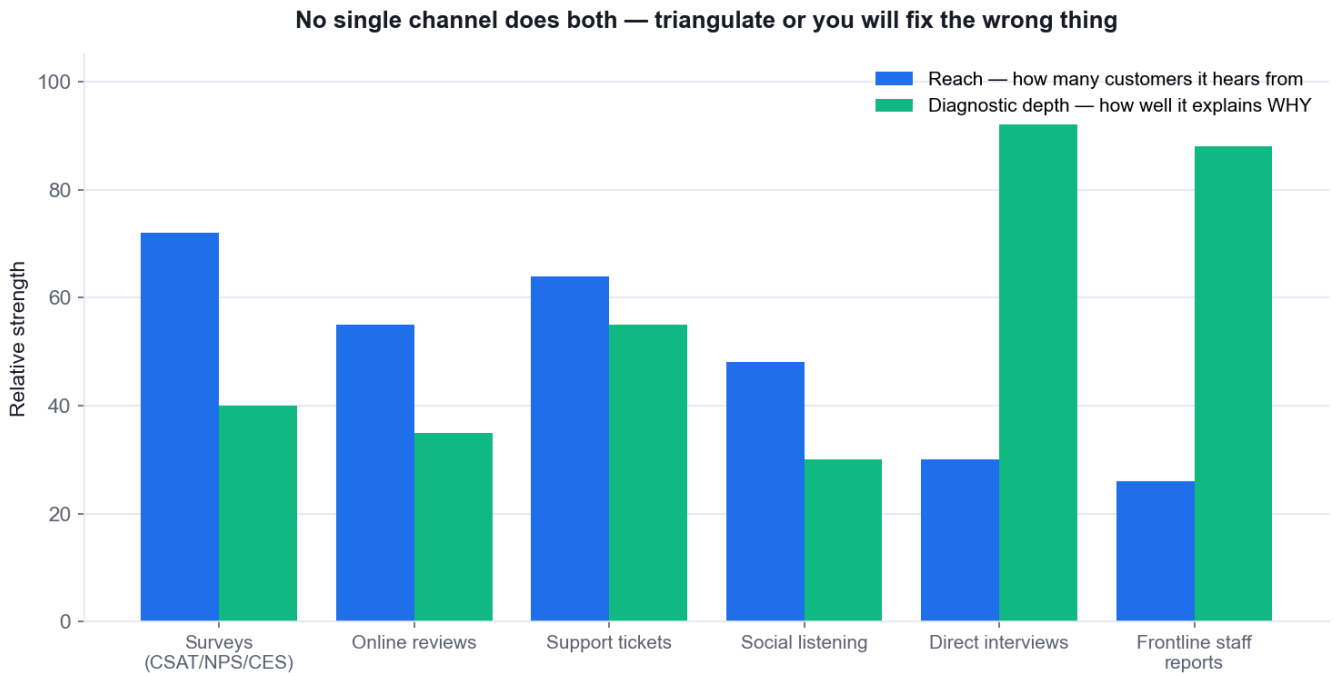
6

Recovery can beat no failure at all

A well-recovered failure often leaves the customer more loyal than a customer who never had a problem.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Feedback Channels — Reach vs Diagnostic Depth



Surveys reach widest

CSAT/NPS/CES cover many customers but rarely explain WHY.

Interviews go deepest

Few customers, but they surface the mechanism behind the score.

Staff reports are gold

Frontline staff see causes that customers only experience as symptoms.

Triangulate always

No single channel does both — one channel alone fixes the wrong thing.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

MEASURING SERVICE

The Three Service Metrics — and What Each Actually Measures

Metric	The question it asks	What it is good for	Its blind spot
CSAT	How satisfied were you with this interaction?	A specific moment — one agent, one ticket, one visit.	Says nothing about the overall relationship.
NPS	How likely are you to recommend us?	The whole relationship and word-of-mouth risk.	One number; gives no reason without a follow-up question.
CES	How much effort did you have to spend?	Predicts disloyalty better than satisfaction does.	Focuses on friction, not on delight or emotional loyalty.

Use them together: CSAT for the moment, NPS for the relationship, CES for the friction.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE SILENT MAJORITY

Most Unhappy Customers Never Complain



~4% complain
Only a small fraction ever tell you there is a problem.

~56% say nothing
They do not complain, do not answer the survey — they just stop coming back.

Silence is not health
The absence of complaints is not evidence of satisfaction.

Go and look
If you only react to complaints, you are managing the visible 4%.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

FROM FEEDBACK TO IMPROVEMENT

Closing the Loop — the Only Cycle That Changes Anything



Feedback with no visible action trains customers to stop giving it. The loop is only closed at step 4.

Collect
Across every channel, deliberately — including from your own staff.

Analyse
Separate symptoms from root causes. The wait is a symptom; the staffing gap is the cause.

Act
An owner, a date and a measure. Anything less is an intention, not an action.

Tell them
The step everyone forgets — and the only one the customer can see.

Feedback with no visible action trains customers to stop giving it — and your early-warning system goes dark.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

WHERE OPERATIONAL INSIGHT COMES FROM

Operational and Personnel Feedback Channels

1

Shift huddles and briefings

Short, daily, structured — the fastest route from frontline observation to action.

2

Frontline incident logs

A written record of what actually happened, not what the system recorded.

3

Team retrospectives

Regular review of what broke and why, with an owner assigned to each fix.

4

Internal escalation reports

Patterns in what gets escalated reveal where authority is missing.

5

Quality assurance scorecards

Reviewed interactions scored for tone, clarity and accuracy.

6

Suggestion and defect channels

A formal route so a known bug never sits in a WhatsApp group for months.

Customer channels tell you WHAT went wrong. Personnel channels are usually the only ones that tell you WHY.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

TOPIC 07 · CASE STUDY

ACTIVITY 7 · 25 MIN

Activity 7 — Closing the Loop — F&B Chain Losing Repeat Customers

THE SCENARIO

Kopi & Co is a Singapore café chain with 9 outlets. Repeat-customer rate has fallen 15% this quarter. Management wants a recovery plan. Here is the feedback that exists:

GOOGLE REVIEWS (rating fell 4.4 → 3.8): 'Waited 25 min for a flat white at Raffles Place, staff seemed overwhelmed.' · 'Ordered on the app, got the wrong drink twice.' · 'Nobody acknowledged me at the counter for 5 minutes.' · 'Food is still great, service has really slipped.'

POST-VISIT SURVEY (CSAT 62%, down from 81%): lowest-scoring item is 'speed of service' (48%); highest is 'product quality' (91%). Only 4% of visitors complete the survey.

FORMAT Case Study + Group Presentation

ROLES Groups of 4–5. Each group presents a 3-minute plan to the class acting as management.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 7 · Activities folder: activities/activity-07/

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 7 — Discussion Questions

1. Sort every piece of feedback by CHANNEL. What is each channel good at capturing, and what does each one miss?
2. Only 4% complete the survey and CSAT is 62%. What is wrong with concluding '62% of our customers are satisfied'?
3. Separate SYMPTOMS from ROOT CAUSES. The 25-minute wait is a symptom — what is causing it?
4. The staff feedback identifies the app modifier bug that support tickets only show as 'wrong item'. What does that tell you about operational feedback channels?
5. Not one customer who left feedback has heard anything back. What does that cost, beyond this quarter?
6. Build the plan: at least 3 strategies, each with an owner, a timeline and a success measure. What will you measure, and when will you know it worked?

20 minutes · Groups of 4–5. Each group presents a 3-minute plan to the class acting as management.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 7 — Debrief

Channel biases: reviews capture the extremes (delighted and furious) and skew negative; surveys capture the compliant middle; tickets capture only what customers bothered to report; staff feedback captures CAUSES the other three only show as symptoms.

4% response rate means severe non-response bias — and roughly 56% of unhappy customers never complain at all. 62% CSAT is the score of the 4% willing to answer, not of the customer base.

Root causes are: (1) the June app update dropped the modifier field, (2) Raffles Place is 2 baristas short since May, (3) there is no closed loop so nothing gets fixed. The 25-minute wait and the wrong drinks are downstream of these.

The staff channel had the highest-value diagnostic information in the whole case — and it was sitting in an informal WhatsApp group because no formal operational feedback channel exists. This is exactly the operational feedback gap.

Silence costs the future: customers who give feedback and see nothing change stop giving feedback, and the early-warning system goes dark. The 15% drop is what you can see; the lost channel is what you cannot.

A good plan is specific: 'Ops Manager fixes the modifier field by 5 Sept, measured by wrong-item tickets falling below 10/week' beats 'improve the app'. Push every group to name an owner, a date and a number.

TEST IT Your plan names 3 root causes (not symptoms), has an owner and date for every strategy, includes a numeric success measure, and contains an explicit mechanism for telling customers what changed.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

08

TOPIC 08

Recovering Difficult Customers

De-escalation · HEARD and LAST · common ground · limits · managing your own emotions

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Topic 8 — Key Concepts

1

Recovery restores the relationship

The goal is not only to fix the fault but to rebuild the trust the fault destroyed.

2

HEARD framework

Hear · Empathize · Apologize · Resolve · Diagnose — let them finish, then act, then prevent the recurrence.

3

LAST framework

Listen · Apologize · Solve · Thank — thank them for surfacing a problem you would otherwise not have seen.

4

Perceived justice has three parts

Customers judge the outcome, the process and how they were treated. Fix the fault and still fail on the last two.

5

Establish common ground

'We both want this resolved fairly today' converts an adversarial exchange into a shared problem.

6

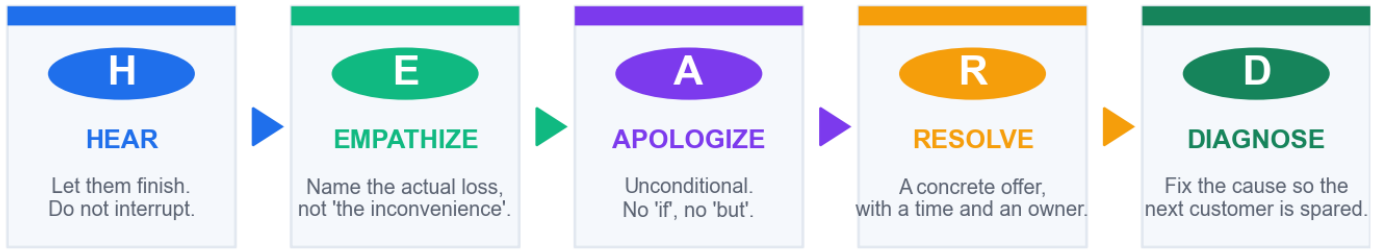
Manage yourself first

Detach from the personal, control breathing and pace, keep language neutral. Composure is the de-escalation tool.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE RECOVERY SEQUENCE

HEARD — the De-escalation Framework



WHY IT WORKS
Customers judge the outcome, the process AND how they were treated. HEARD is the only framework that addresses all three — which is why a well-recovered failure can leave a customer more loyal than one who never had a problem.

Hear then Empathize
Let them finish, then name the actual loss — not 'the inconvenience'.

Apologize unconditionally
No 'if', no 'but'. A conditional apology is heard as a denial.

Resolve concretely
An offer with a time and an owner, made now rather than promised later.

Diagnose the cause
Fix the process so the next customer never meets this problem.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

PICK ONE AND USE IT CONSISTENTLY

Two Recovery Frameworks — HEARD and LAST

Stage	HEARD	LAST	What it achieves
1	Hear	Listen	The customer gets to finish — and you get the real facts.
2	Empathize	Apologize	The customer's experience is acknowledged as legitimate.
3	Apologize	Solve	Ownership is taken and a concrete route forward appears.
4	Resolve	Thank	The problem is fixed — and surfacing it is treated as a favour.
5	Diagnose	—	The root cause is closed so it cannot recur.

LAST is faster for a live counter or call; HEARD adds the Diagnose step that prevents the recurrence.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

WHY A CORRECT FIX CAN STILL FAIL

Perceived Justice — What the Customer Is Actually Judging

1 OUTCOME

Did I get a fair result? The refund, the replacement, the fix. Usually the only part organisations measure.

2 PROCESS

Was it fair and reasonable to get there? How long, how many repeats, how many transfers.

3 TREATMENT

Was I treated with respect and taken seriously? Often the part that decides whether they return.

4 THE TRAP

Fix the outcome, fail the other two, and the customer still leaves — while your metrics show a resolved case.

When you cannot change the outcome, process and treatment are still entirely within your control.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

COMMON GROUND · LIMITS · EMOTIONS

Managing Yourself in the Difficult Conversation

1. **Establish common ground first**
   'We both want this resolved fairly today' turns an opponent into a co-problem-solver.

2. **Depersonalise**
   They are angry at the situation and the company. Absorbing it as a personal attack costs you the next customer too.

3. **Control your physiology**
   Slow the breath, slow the speech, drop the volume. Composure IS the de-escalation tool.

4. **Set limits once, calmly**
   State clearly what you can and cannot do. Repeating it or defending it invites haggling.

5. **Never haggle over a loss**
   Give the maximum you can authorise immediately, then escalate the rest openly and on their side.

6. **Close the loop afterwards**
   Tell them what changed a week later. That single follow-up converts detractors.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

ACTIVITY 8 · 15 MIN

Activity 8 — Service Recovery Under Pressure — The Wedding Catering Failure

THE SCENARIO

You are the Duty Manager for a Singapore catering company. Yesterday you catered a 200-guest wedding at a hotel ballroom in Novena. Three failures occurred: the vegetarian main course (40 portions, pre-ordered and confirmed in writing) was never loaded onto the truck; service started 35 minutes late; and the wedding cake was delivered with visible damage to one side.

The bride's father, Mr Wong, paid S$18,400. He is in your office now. He has photographs. He has already posted a one-star review naming your company. He is demanding a full refund and says he will 'make sure nobody in Singapore uses you again'.

What you know internally: the vegetarian order WAS in the system — the kitchen printed the run sheet before the final amendment was saved, a known gap flagged twice by kitchen staff and never fixed. Your authority extends to a 40% refund; anything beyond that needs the Director, who is contactable.

FORMAT Role Play + Case Study

ROLES Pairs or trios. A = Duty Manager, B = Mr Wong, C = observer scoring against HEARD.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 8 · Activities folder: activities/activity-08/

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 8 — Discussion Questions

1. Apply HEARD to this case. Write what you would actually SAY at each of the five stages.
2. You cannot undo the wedding. What are you actually recovering, and is recovery even possible here?
3. Mr Wong demands a full refund; you can authorise 40%. How do you set that limit without sounding like you are haggling over his daughter's wedding?
4. The kitchen flagged the run-sheet gap twice and nothing was done. Do you tell Mr Wong that? Argue both sides.
5. Perceived justice has three parts — outcome, process and treatment. Which of the three can you still influence here?
6. Design the process fix. What exactly changes so this cannot happen to the next customer?

15 minutes · Pairs or trios. A = Duty Manager, B = Mr Wong, C = observer scoring against HEARD.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 8 — Debrief

HEARD in practice — Hear: let him show the photographs and finish, however long it takes. Empathize: 'this was your daughter's wedding and we damaged it' — name the actual loss, not 'the inconvenience'. Apologize: unconditional, no 'if' and no 'but'. Resolve: a concrete offer, now. Diagnose: the run-sheet gap, named to him as a real fix.

What you are recovering is not the wedding — it is Mr Wong's standing. He chose this vendor and it failed in front of 200 guests including his extended family. The dignity loss is larger than the money.

Setting the limit: never haggle. State the 40% as immediate and unconditional, then say you are taking the rest to the Director TODAY with your own recommendation, and give a time you will call back. Being on his side of the table is the move.

Disclosing the known gap: strong arguments both ways. Disclosing shows honesty and makes the fix credible; it also hands him evidence of negligence. Most groups land on acknowledging a 'known process gap we failed to close' without the detail that it was flagged twice — accurate, honest, not self-incriminating. There is no single right answer here and the discussion is the point.

Outcome is largely fixed (money is all that is left). But PROCESS and TREATMENT are entirely still in your hands — and research on perceived justice says those two often matter more than the refund amount.

The fix: lock the run sheet against the live order record at print time, or block printing until amendments are closed. Then close the loop — tell Mr Wong what changed, in writing, a week later. That last step is what converts a detractor.

TEST IT All five HEARD stages were delivered, your apology contained no conditional words, you set the 40% limit once without haggling, and you produced a written process fix with an owner.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

09

TOPIC 09

Understanding When to Escalate

Functional vs hierarchical escalation · triggers · the three-strike rule · documentation · POHA

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Topic 9 — Key Concepts

1

Escalation is a decision, not a failure

Handing over to the right authority or expertise faster is better service than struggling on alone.

2

Functional vs hierarchical

Functional escalation goes sideways to expertise; hierarchical escalation goes upward to authority.

3

Angry is not the same as abusive

An angry customer attacks the problem. An abusive customer attacks you — that line is the escalation trigger.

4

Know the trigger behaviours

Vulgarity, personal insults, discriminatory remarks, legal threats and any threat of physical harm.

5

The three-strike rule

Two clear, calm warnings that the behaviour must stop, then escalate or end the interaction.

6

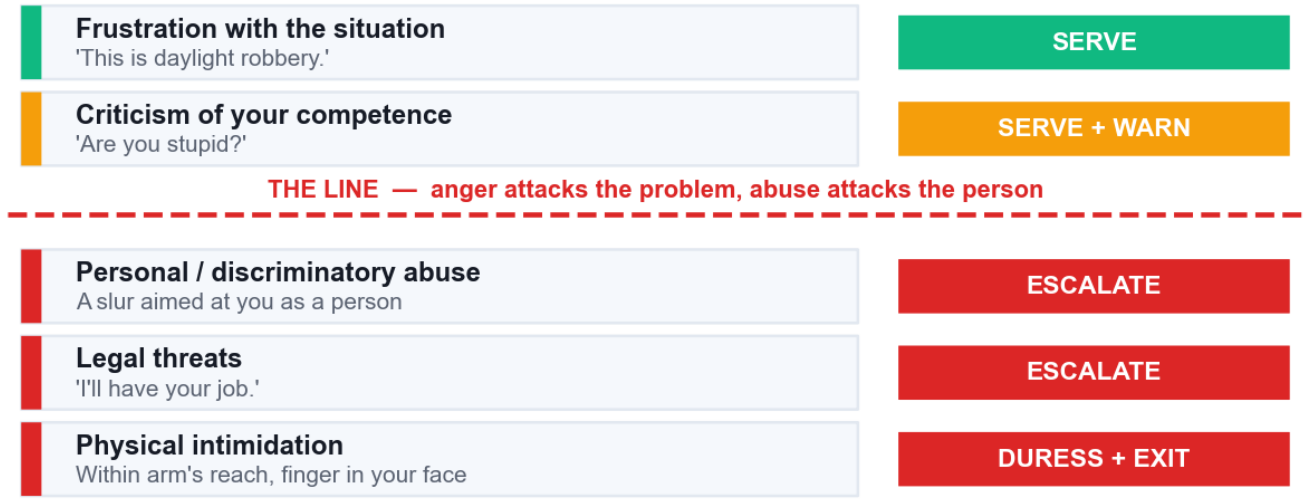
Singapore protects service staff

POHA 2014 criminalises workplace harassment; incidents can go to TAFEP or the police. Document everything.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE ESCALATION THRESHOLD

Where the Line Is — Anger vs Abuse



Waiting until you feel physically unsafe means you served through the abuse.

Anger attacks the problem

Loud, frustrated, even rude about the situation — still serviceable.

Abuse attacks the person

Slurs, personal or discriminatory attacks. This is the threshold.

Threats escalate instantly

Legal threats go to a manager; physical threats end the interaction.

Do not wait to feel unsafe

If you wait for physical fear, you have already served through the abuse.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE ESCALATION DECISION

Two Kinds of Escalation — Know Which One You Need

FUNCTIONAL (sideways)

- The issue needs EXPERTISE you do not have.
- Technical faults, billing calculations, specialist products.
- Goes to a specialist team, not up the hierarchy.
- The customer is reasonable — the problem is hard.
- Introduce the specialist and hand over the context.

HIERARCHICAL (upward)

- The issue needs AUTHORITY you do not have.
- Goodwill beyond your limit, policy exceptions, abuse.
- Goes to a supervisor or duty manager.
- The problem may be simple — your mandate is the constraint.
- Brief your supervisor before they meet the customer.

Same customer and same complaint can need either route — diagnose whether you are short of expertise or short of authority.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

SETTING AND HOLDING THE BOUNDARY

The Three-Strike Rule in Practice

1. **Warning one — name the behaviour**
   'I want to help you with this, but I can't continue if you speak to me that way.' Calm, specific, never sarcastic.

2. **Warning two — state the consequence**
   'If that continues I'll need to hand this to my supervisor and end our conversation.'

3. **Act on it**
   Escalate or end. A warning you do not act on teaches the customer that the boundary is fictional.

4. **Immediate escalation overrides**
   Slurs, discriminatory abuse and any physical threat skip the warnings entirely.

5. **Withdraw properly**
   Hand over in front of the customer, then physically step away. Do not keep serving after escalating.

6. **Document verbatim**
   Date, time, exact words, witnesses, CCTV reference. Paraphrase destroys the evidence.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

YOU ARE NOT REQUIRED TO ABSORB ABUSE

Your Legal Protection in Singapore

1

POHA 2014

The Protection from Harassment Act criminalises harassment, including abuse of workers at work.

2

TAFEP

The Tripartite Alliance for Fair & Progressive Employment Practices takes workplace harassment reports.

3

Police report

Threats of violence and serious harassment are criminal matters, not service problems.

4

Employer duty

Your employer is responsible for providing a workplace safe from harassment.

5

Documentation is evidence

Verbatim wording, times and witnesses are what any report will turn on.

6

Aftercare is not optional

A break, a supervisor debrief and a next-day follow-up after an abusive incident.

'It's part of the job' is not the standard. Singapore law explicitly protects public-facing workers.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

ACTIVITY 9 · 15 MIN

Activity 9 — Drawing the Line — Escalation and Abuse at a Service Counter

THE SCENARIO

You are a service officer at a telco flagship store on Orchard Road. Mr Douglas Teo is disputing a S$680 roaming bill from a trip to Australia. He says he was never told data roaming was not included. The account notes show a confirmation SMS was sent and opened. The charge is valid under the contract.

The interaction escalates over 8 minutes:

- 0:00 He raises his voice: 'This is daylight robbery.'
- 2:00 'Are you stupid? Can you even read English?'
- 4:00 He calls you an offensive name related to your race.
- 5:30 'I'm going to CASE, and I'll have your job. What's your full name and NRIC?'
- 7:00 He steps behind the counter line, moves within arm's reach, and points a finger in your face.

Other customers are present. Your supervisor is on the shop floor. There is a duress button under the counter and CCTV covering the area.

FORMAT Role Play + Decision Exercise

ROLES Trios. A = Service Officer, B = Mr Teo (trainer may play this role), C = supervisor/observer.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 9 · Activities folder: activities/activity-09/

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 9 — Discussion Questions

1. Go through the timeline. At each timestamp, classify the behaviour as ANGRY or ABUSIVE. Where exactly is the line?
2. Which timestamp is the point of no return — where continuing to serve is the wrong decision? Justify it.
3. Apply the three-strike rule to this timeline. What are your two warnings, word for word?
4. Is this functional escalation or hierarchical escalation? Would your answer change if the dispute were technical rather than behavioural?
5. He demands your full name and NRIC. What are you obliged to give, and what are you not?
6. At 7:00 he is within arm's reach and pointing at your face. What do you do in the next 5 seconds, in order?
7. What must go into the incident report, and why does the exact wording he used need to be recorded verbatim?

15 minutes · Trios. A = Service Officer, B = Mr Teo (trainer may play this role), C = supervisor/observer.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

Activity 9 — Debrief

The line: 0:00 and 2:00 are anger directed at the situation and then at your competence — unpleasant but serviceable. 4:00 is the crossing point: a racial slur is abuse of the PERSON and is a criminal matter under POHA, not a service problem.

Point of no return is 4:00, not 7:00. Most learners wait for the physical proximity. Waiting until you feel physically unsafe means you served through the abuse — the threshold is the slur, and it is not negotiable or 'part of the job'.

Warnings must be calm, specific and behavioural: 'Mr Teo, I want to help you with this bill, but I cannot continue if you speak to me that way.' Second: 'If that continues I will need to hand this to my supervisor and end our conversation.' Never sarcastic, never raised.

This is HIERARCHICAL escalation — it needs authority, not expertise. A technical roaming dispute would be FUNCTIONAL escalation to a billing specialist. Same customer, same bill, entirely different escalation path.

You give your first name or staff ID — that is standard and reasonable. You never give your NRIC or personal details. Deflect: 'my name is X and my staff ID is Y, and my supervisor will give you the complaint reference.'

At 7:00, in order: step back to restore distance, keep hands visible and open, do not turn your back, say clearly 'please step back behind the counter', signal or press for the supervisor, and press the duress button if he does not comply. Do not attempt to win the exchange.

The report needs date, time, location, the exact words used verbatim, witnesses present, CCTV reference, actions taken and who was notified. Verbatim matters because POHA and any police report turn on what was actually said — paraphrase destroys the evidence.

TEST IT You identified 4:00 as the escalation threshold, delivered two calm behavioural warnings, handed over without continuing to serve, and produced an incident report containing the verbatim wording and a CCTV reference.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

WRAP-UP

Course Summary & Next Steps

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

LEARNING OUTCOMES DELIVERED

What You Achieved Today

1. **Understood the service chain**
   External and internal customers, and why service quality is a chain not a department. (LO1)
2. **Built a service attitude**
   Appearance, smile, energy, positivity and positive language under pressure. (LO1)
3. **Identified customer needs**
   Active listening, open questioning, and the four levels of addressing needs. (LO1)
4. **Served across every channel**
   In person, on the phone, and in writing — matching channel to issue. (LO1)
5. **Turned feedback into improvement**
   Feedback channels, closing the loop, and root cause vs symptom. (LO2)
6. **Recovered and escalated safely**
   HEARD and LAST, perceived justice, the three-strike rule and POHA. (LO2)

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

The absence of complaints is not evidence of satisfaction.

Go and look. Ask your customers, ask your frontline, and close the loop where it matters.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

WE'RE HERE TO HELP

Support

1

Email

enquiry@tertiaryinfotech.com

2

Telephone

+65 6100 0613

3

Website

www.tertiarycourses.com.sg

4

LMS / TMS portal

lms-tms.tertiaryinfotech.com — courseware and certificates.

5

During the course

Ask your trainer at any point — including during the activities.

6

After the course

Contact us any time; we support learners after the class ends.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

COURSE FEEDBACK

Course Feedback

1

Share your feedback

Tell us what worked and what we can improve — your comments shape the next run.

2

Course feedback form

Complete the short feedback form at https://lms-tms.tertiaryinfotech.com/

3

Your certificate

Your certificate of completion will be emailed to you after the course.

4

Keep your materials

Download the slides and Learner Guide from the LMS/TMS portal.

5

Put it into practice

Pick one habit from today — positive language, HEARD or closing the loop — and use it this week.

6

Stay in touch

Questions after class? Email enquiry@tertiaryinfotech.com.

Your feedback helps us keep this course practical and current.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

SEE YOU AT THE COUNTER

Thank You!

You can now collect customer feedback, read what it actually says, and turn it into service that keeps customers.

© 2026 Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd